STORE LAYOUT CONCEPTS PROPOSAL

Supporting Customer Flow and Store Recovery Efficiency

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This proposal presents three operational design concepts for TJ Maxx stores: a Decision Support Zone, a Checkout Flow Enhancement Strategy, and a Behavior-Guided Store Organization Concept. These concepts aim to create a more organized shopping environment, reduce front-end congestion, support more efficient labor allocation, and introduce a scalable approach that could inform future in-store design considerations.

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Executive Summary

This proposal presents a store layout strategy designed to support operational efficiency, front-end flow, and sustainable labor utilization within TJ Maxx stores. The objective is to introduce practical layout strategies that work with natural shopping behaviors while reducing operational friction that places recurring demands on store associates.

In high-traffic retail environments, everyday shopping behaviors, such as customers reconsidering items at different points in the store, placing merchandise in unintended locations, or leaving carts and items in transitional areas, can gradually create additional recovery and organization demands for store teams. While each instance is minor, these recurring tasks accumulate into meaningful reactive workload that affects associate time allocation, store presentation, and overall flow. This proposal outlines a set of layout and flow strategies designed to support smoother store operations while maintaining TJ Maxx's successful off-price, discovery-driven shopping experience. The framework consists of three complementary approaches:

1. **Decision Support Zone**
   A structured decision-support approach that gives customers natural moments to organize and reconsider items during their shopping journey. This helps reduce merchandise being left in unintended locations throughout the store, lowering recurring recovery workload and allowing associates to focus more on customer service and floor support.

2. **Checkout Flow Enhancement Strategy**
   A front-end flow strategy designed to better accommodate different customer readiness states at checkout. By introducing structured queue entry options within a shared checkout area, this approach helps distribute congestion, support smoother line movement, and allow stores to manage transaction complexity more effectively. The strategy also incorporates flexible service counters that can shift between returns and standard checkout as needed, helping balance workload while maintaining service visibility and loss-prevention awareness. By reducing perceived checkout friction, this approach not only supports purchase completion during busy periods but also contributes to a more positive end-of-visit experience, which plays an important role in encouraging repeat store visits.

3. **Behavior-Guided Store Organization Concept**
   A storewide concept grounded in behavioral guidance, shared responsibility, and friction-based design, recognizing that customers naturally choose the lowest-effort option available to them. The concept introduces clearly visible visual cues and light, positive, reward-based reinforcement elements that acknowledge and encourage considerate in-store behavior. By making organized actions easier, socially reinforced, and mildly engaging, this approach reduces recurring merchandise recovery labor, supports store presentation standards, and contributes to a more positive end-to-end shopping experience that encourages repeat visits while remaining aligned with TJ Maxx's treasure-hunt experience.

Individually, each approach targets a specific source of recurring operational workload, whether related to merchandise recovery, checkout congestion, or store organization. Collectively, they form an integrated and scalable framework that supports more efficient labor utilization,

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smoother front-end flow, and a more consistently shoppable store environment, without altering the core off-price value proposition.

This proposal is developed as a store-specific case study based on observed operational patterns within a single TJ Maxx location. While the concepts draw on general retail flow and behavior principles, their spatial application reflects the layout and traffic dynamics of this store. The intent is not to prescribe a universal solution, but to demonstrate how targeted, behavior-aware layout strategies can be tested and adapted across different store formats as appropriate.

Problem Statement

TJ Maxx is widely recognized for offering affordable pricing paired with quality merchandise, making it a destination customers actively choose for value-driven shopping. However, as store traffic increases, the in-store experience, particularly around store organization and checkout, can become a deciding factor in how often customers choose to return.

Visible merchandise displacement, crowded aisles, and long checkout lines can create friction that discourages repeat visits, even among customers who otherwise enjoy the treasure-hunt experience. While these conditions are present throughout the day, they become most noticeable during high-traffic periods, when their impact on both customer experience and store operations is amplified. These conditions not only affect customer perception but also increase recovery and front-end workload for store teams, placing additional pressure on associate time and store presentation standards.

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Over time, these compounded pressures require store teams to rely heavily on reactive labor to maintain order and manage flow, limiting capacity for proactive customer support and consistent floor coverage.

Proposed Solutions

To address the recurring operational pressures identified above, namely merchandise recovery workload, checkout congestion, and customer experience friction. This proposal introduces three complementary layout and flow concepts designed to support store operations while preserving the discovery-driven shopping experience central to TJ Maxx. Rather than relying on additional staffing or fully automated systems, these concepts focus on aligning store design with natural customer behavior to reduce reactive labor and support more sustainable day-to-day operations.

1. **Decision Support Zone**

Observation

Store associates spend a significant portion of their time walking the sales floor to retrieve and re-shelve misplaced merchandise. Items that customers decide not to purchase are frequently left on nearby racks, fixtures, or transitional surfaces, creating continuous recovery work throughout the day.

Concept
The Decision Support Zone introduces clearly designated areas where customers can place items they decide not to purchase after picking them up. Rather than leaving merchandise in unintended locations, customers are given an intuitive and socially accepted place to set items aside, reducing random product displacement across the store.

Objective
The primary goal of this concept is to reduce the amount of reactive labor required for constant tidying and merchandise recovery. By concentrating reconsidered items into designated zones, store associates can shift from continuous, scattered recovery to more structured and time-efficient clearing routines.

Execution Approach
Decision Support Zones would be positioned at key aisle intersections and mid-hallway transition points, functioning as visible "roundabout" spaces within the store. These locations align with natural pause points where customers frequently stop, compare items, or reconsider purchases while moving between sections. By placing the zones in shared circulation areas rather than within individual departments, customers can easily access them without re-entering a specific section or searching for a designated drop-off point.

The zones would be created using existing fixtures or low-profile racks to maintain clear sightlines and avoid disrupting traffic flow. Because items are consolidated into a small number of highly visible locations, associates can clear the zones during scheduled intervals determined by store operations, rather than spending time continuously retrieving misplaced items from across the sales floor. This approach supports more predictable recovery routines while remaining flexible to differences in store layout, traffic intensity, and staffing levels.

Customer Engagement & Utilization
To encourage customer participation, each zone would feature light, friendly messaging that normalizes and invites use of the space. Titles or phrases such as "*I like it, but maybe next time*," "*Good stuff! Just not today*," or "*Girl, you need this!*" draw attention without sounding instructional. The tone is playful rather than corrective, helping customers feel comfortable using the zone while adding a moment of interaction that aligns with the brand's approachable, discovery-driven atmosphere.

Placement Principles
Placement of Decision Support Zones should be guided by observed patterns of merchandise displacement rather than fixed distances alone. In-store observation suggests that misplaced items appear frequently throughout the sales floor and accumulate quickly, even early in the day, indicating that item reconsideration occurs repeatedly across the shopping journey.

To support consistent access without over-saturating the store, zone placement can be guided by a simple operational spacing rule:

$$\text{Return Zone Spacing} = \frac{D}{Z}$$

Where:

D = average total walking distance or number of steps a customer travels during a typical

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shopping trip
Z = number of return points the store chooses to provide (typically 2–3)

This model is intended as an operational rule of thumb rather than a statistical calculation. The objective is to space return points frequently enough that customers do not need to search for one, but not so densely that they clutter the sales floor or disrupt traffic flow. Dividing the average distance between reconsideration moments by the number of return points provides stores with a practical framework for thinking about placement while allowing flexibility to adjust based on layout, traffic patterns, and staffing considerations.

In practice, this approach aligns with positioning Decision Support Zones at key aisle intersections and mid-hallway transition points, functioning as visible "roundabout" spaces within the store. These locations align with natural pause points where customers frequently stop, compare items, or reconsider purchases while moving between sections. By placing the zones in shared circulation areas rather than within individual departments, customers can easily access them without re-entering a specific section or searching for a designated drop-off point. Stores can further refine placement over time by periodically noting where misplaced items most frequently appear and adjusting zone locations or quantity accordingly.

2. Checkout Flow Enhancement Strategy

Observation

Checkout congestion is not limited to peak traffic periods. Even during lower-traffic hours, checkout lines may remain long due to return processing, register allocation, and transaction complexity common in off-price retail environments.

When wait time feels uncertain or disproportionate to basket size, customers appear to respond in different ways. Some adapt their behavior by attempting to secure a place in line early while continuing to browse, indicating high purchase intent paired with sensitivity to perceived waiting cost. Others may delay or abandon purchases altogether when checkout friction outweighs the perceived value of completing the transaction.

At the same time, checkout automation (such as self-checkout) presents challenges in off-price retail environments, including increased shrink exposure, frequent price changes, ticketing complexity, and the need for associate verification at the point of sale. These factors increase both operational risk and implementation cost, making automation difficult to sustain at scale.

Concept

The Checkout Flow Enhancement Strategy introduces a dual-entry checkout flow that accommodates different customer readiness states while maintaining clear staff sightlines, impulse opportunities, and checkout integrity appropriate for TJ Maxx's operating environment.

Rather than focusing on checkout speed or automation, the concept emphasizes flow clarity and flexibility. By offering an additional, clearly defined path for customers who are ready to check out, the strategy reduces ambiguity at the front end and lowers the perceived cost of entering a line. Customers who prefer a traditional checkout experience continue to use the existing front-end queue without disruption.

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At the same time, the concept preserves operational control by keeping all checkout activity within a shared, observable zone and by enabling registers to flex between returns and standard checkout. This allows the front end to adapt to changing transaction mix while supporting a calmer, more predictable end-of-visit experience that encourages completion of purchases and repeat visits.

Objective

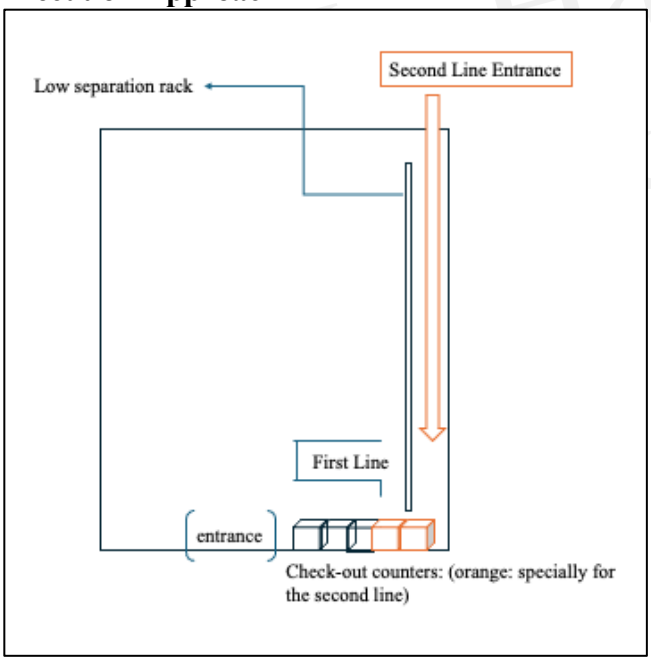
The objective of this strategy is to support a smoother, more predictable front-end experience while preserving operational control, clear staff sightlines, and checkout integrity.

Specifically, this strategy aims to:

- Reduce visible congestion at checkout, even when overall store traffic is moderate
- Help customer flow spread more naturally across available registers, reducing single-point bottlenecks
- Allow staff to shift checkout capacity more easily when return volume increases
- Reduce lost purchases caused by unclear, stressful, or discouraging queue conditions
- Improve the final stage of the shopping experience, supporting repeat visits

These objectives prioritize clarity, comfort, and conversion, rather than transaction speed alone.

Execution Approach



Rather than replacing or restructuring the existing checkout line, the strategy adds a secondary checkout line, where its queue entrance is located at the very back of the store, positioned along the outermost side of the sales floor (left or right, whichever is farthest from the main customer entrance). This placement reduces cross-traffic with incoming shoppers, limits movement through central shopping areas, and supports loss-prevention by guiding checkout-bound customers along a controlled edge path. The primary front-end queue remains unchanged and continues to operate as usual.

From the back-of-store entrance, customers follow a direct, wall-adjacent pathway toward checkout that is visually separated from the shopping area using low-profile racks. This separation creates a clear transition zone that supports faster and more efficient movement while maintaining open sightlines for associate monitoring. The pathway leads to one to two designated checkout counters positioned immediately adjacent to the main checkout area, ensuring shared visibility, associate proximity, and avoidance of isolated checkout activity.

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These counters are designed as flexible service points that can shift between returns and standard checkout as needed, allowing staff to balance workload dynamically while maintaining service visibility and loss-prevention awareness.

Placement Principles
The secondary queue path is designed to support speed, clarity, and operational oversight without disrupting the core shopping experience or front-end merchandising strategy.

- Edge-Based Placement
  The path should run along the outer edge of the store, positioned on the side farthest from the main entrance to reduce cross-traffic and limit movement through central merchandise zones.
- Low-Profile Separation
  Separation between the queue path and shopping area should be achieved using low-profile fixtures that define movement while preserving clear staff sightlines.
- Movement-First Design
  Separation fixtures should remain lightly merchandised, prioritizing uninterrupted movement and reducing hesitation or re-browsing within the pathway.
- Checkout Convergence
  The pathway should terminate at one to two checkout counters located on the very side of the checkout area, positioned adjacent to the main checkout counters rather than centrally or in isolation. This placement maintains associate proximity, clear staff sightlines, and loss-prevention alignment while keeping all checkout activity within a shared, observable zone.

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3. Behavior-Guided Store Organization Concept

Concept
The Behavior-Guided Store Organization Concept is a storewide approach that uses behavioral guidance and environmental design to support a more organized, navigable shopping experience through shared responsibility between the store and its customers.

Customer behavior naturally adapts throughout a shopping visit. As customers browse, compare options, and move through different areas of the store, they pause, change direction, and make moment-by-moment decisions about where to place items and how to move through the space. Rather than treating these behaviors as exceptions, the concept recognizes them as a normal part of the shopping process.

Building on this understanding, the concept applies subtle, non-instructional influence by shaping the environment so that the lowest-effort choice is also the most store-supportive choice. Through clearly visible visual cues and light, positive, reward-based reinforcement, customers are gently guided toward considerate placement and movement without being told what to do or feeling corrected.

By making organized actions easier, socially reinforced, and mildly engaging, the store establishes a long-term, self-reinforcing system that supports presentation standards, reduces

recurring disorder, and enhances the overall shopping experience while preserving the open, exploratory character associated with TJ Maxx's treasure-hunt environment.

Objective

When applied as a decision-making lens for store organization, the Behavior-Guided Store Organization Concept supports store standards and customer experience through shared participation, rather than increased enforcement or labor intensity. It supports the following outcomes:

- Lower non–value-added labor
  By shaping environments where orderly behavior is the lowest-effort option, the store reduces the need for constant, reactive tidying by associates over time.
- Maintaining the store environment together with customers
  Through subtle environmental influence customers naturally participate in maintaining order without rules, instruction, or corrective messaging.
- Increased interaction and repeat visits
  A store environment that feels intuitive, responsive, and lightly engaging strengthens customer connection, contributing to higher comfort, longer-term familiarity, and repeat visits.

Examples

The behavior-guided approach described above is already implied in both 1.Decision Support Zone and 2.Checkout Flow Enhancement Strategy, where layout and flow guide customer behavior without instruction. The same mindset can be applied more broadly across store organization through simple, everyday touchpoints.

An additional example is shopping cart return areas. In many stores, cart return zones are already physically designated using metal rails or boundaries, yet carts are still frequently left elsewhere, even when customers clearly see where carts are meant to go. This suggests that awareness alone is not sufficient to guide behavior consistently.

By strengthening visual cues, such as clearer spatial emphasis, alignment, or visual contrast around the cart return area, and pairing them with light, positive, reward-based reinforcement (for example, a friendly "Thank you" message), the store can subtly shift behavior. Customers feel noticed and acknowledged for using the designated zone, rather than corrected for failing to do so. Over time, this combination makes the intended action feel both easier and socially reinforced, encouraging more consistent participation without instruction or enforcement.

This same principle can be extended to other shared-use and transition areas throughout the store, where visual clarity and positive reinforcement work together to support orderly behavior while preserving the open, low-pressure shopping experience associated with TJ Maxx.

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Goals & Objectives

This proposal is designed to support smoother store operations by aligning layout and flow with natural customer behavior. The objective is not to change how customers shop, but to reduce recurring operational friction that increases reactive labor and front-end congestion.

Specifically, the proposed concepts support more predictable merchandise recovery, clearer checkout flow, and sustained loss-prevention visibility while preserving TJ Maxx's discovery-driven shopping experience. Together, they provide a practical framework that stores can observe, test, and adjust based on local layout and traffic patterns.

Budget & Resources

The proposed concepts are intentionally low-cost and operationally practical. They rely primarily on existing fixtures, minor layout adjustments, and signage rather than new infrastructure or additional staffing.

Because the strategies focus on reallocating space and guiding behavior rather than adding labor or automation, they can be tested incrementally and adapted using current store resources.

Risk Assessment

As with any layout adjustment, there is a risk that placement or signage could create unintended congestion or visual clutter if overused. These risks can be mitigated through low-profile fixtures, preserved sightlines, and limited initial rollout.

All concepts are designed to be flexible and adjustable, allowing stores to refine placement, quantity, and messaging based on observed customer response and operational needs.

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Expected Benefits

Over time, these strategies are expected to reduce scattered merchandise displacement, lower non–value-added recovery labor, and support smoother front-end flow during both peak and moderate traffic periods.

From a customer perspective, clearer organization and more predictable checkout flow contribute to a calmer end-of-visit experience, supporting purchase completion and repeat visits while maintaining the treasure-hunt atmosphere.

Conclusion

This proposal presents a store-specific, behavior-aware layout framework intended to support TJ Maxx's existing operations rather than replace them. By working with natural shopping behavior

and emphasizing visibility, flexibility, and shared responsibility, the concepts offer a scalable approach that can be tested and refined at the store level.

The intent is not to prescribe a universal solution, but to demonstrate how small, thoughtful design adjustments can support operational efficiency, labor sustainability, and customer experience without altering TJ Maxx's core value proposition.

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